

The Tortoise Who Wanted Wings

A story about appreciating what makes you unique and not comparing yourself to others

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

For children ages 4-10

[Illustration: Beautiful, colorful cover art depicting the main character]

Dedication

To every child who has ever wished to be someone else you are wonderfully made, exactly as you are.

Page 1

In the Emerald Valley, where waterfalls tumbled over mossy rocks and butterflies danced in the breeze, there lived a tortoise named Taro.

Taro was a fine tortoise – strong shell, sturdy legs, a calm and patient heart.

But every morning, Taro would look up at the sky and watch the birds soar overhead, and his heart would ache with longing.

'Oh, how I wish I could fly,' he would sigh. 'Birds are so lucky. They can go anywhere. I'm just stuck on the ground.'

[Illustration: A tortoise looking longingly up at the sky where colorful birds soar freely overhead, standing in a beautiful valley with waterfalls, his expression wistful and envious]

Page 2

Taro's best friend was a cheerful robin named Ruby. She visited him every day, landing on his shell.

'Good morning, Taro! Isn't it a beautiful day?' Ruby would chirp.

'It would be more beautiful from up there,' Taro always replied, looking skyward.

Ruby tilted her head. 'But you have such wonderful things down here! The flowers, the mushrooms, the '

'I'd trade them all for wings,' Taro interrupted. He said this every single day.

[Illustration: A friendly red robin perched on Taro the tortoise's shell, chatting with him, Taro gazing upward at the sky instead of at the beautiful flowers and nature around him]

Page 3

One day, a strange old owl appeared in the valley. Her name was Wisdom, and she was known for granting one wish to those who truly desired it.

'I hear you want wings, little tortoise,' Wisdom said, her amber eyes glowing.

'More than anything!' Taro said eagerly.

Wisdom studied him carefully. 'Very well. I will give you wings for three days. But listen carefully: you must give up your shell to make room for them.'

'My shell?' Taro hesitated for only a moment. 'Deal!'

[Illustration: An ancient mystical owl with glowing amber eyes perched on a branch above Taro, offering a magical bargain, Taro looking excited and eager, magical sparkles in the air]

Page 4

WHOOSH! In a swirl of golden feathers, Taro's shell dissolved and two green wings sprouted from his back.

He was lighter! He could feel the wind on his bare back. He flapped once, twice and LIFTED OFF THE GROUND!

'I'm FLYING!' Taro shouted with pure joy. 'I'm actually flying!'

He soared above the trees, above the waterfall, up into the clouds. The world below was tiny and beautiful.

Ruby flew beside him, laughing. 'How does it feel?'

'INCREDIBLE!' Taro whooped, doing a loop in the air.

[Illustration: Taro with green wings instead of his shell, flying joyfully above the Emerald Valley with Ruby beside him, the landscape stunning below, pure happiness on his face]

Page 5

The first day of flying was the best day of Taro's life.

He saw the valley from above the waterfall looked like a silver ribbon, the meadow like a green blanket.

He raced Ruby through the clouds and chased butterflies over the treetops.

He felt free. Light. Unlimited. Everything he'd ever dreamed of.

When night came, Taro was exhausted but blissfully happy. 'This is the life,' he murmured, falling asleep on a high branch.

[Illustration: Taro perched on a high tree branch at sunset after a day of flying, exhausted but ecstatic, the valley spread out beautifully below him, stars beginning to appear]

Page 6

But that night, it rained. Hard.

Without his shell, Taro had nothing to protect him from the cold, driving rain. His bare skin was soaked and freezing.

He shivered on the branch, unable to tuck himself away like he always used to.

'Just one bad night,' Taro told himself through chattering teeth. 'It's worth it for the flying.'

But a small seed of doubt had been planted.

[Illustration: Taro on a tree branch in heavy rain, completely exposed without his shell, shivering and miserable, water dripping off him with no protection from the cold]

Page 7

On day two, Taro flew to visit his old friend, the hedgehog named Bramble.

But when he landed, a hawk spotted him a small, unprotected creature on the ground.

SWOOOOSH! The hawk dove at him with razor talons. Taro screamed and tried to fly away, but he was too slow on the takeoff.

Without his shell, there was nothing to protect him. He dove behind a rock just in time, the hawk's claws scraping stone.

Taro's heart hammered. In all his years as a tortoise, he'd never once been afraid of hawks. His shell had always kept him safe.

[Illustration: A terrified Taro with wings but no shell diving behind a rock as a hawk swoops down with sharp talons, a near-miss, showing how vulnerable he is without protection]

Page 8

That afternoon, Taro passed the meadow where the tortoises gathered to eat clover. His family and friends were there, slowly munching on the sweet plants, safe in their shells.

'Come join us, Taro!' his mother called. But Taro looked at the clover and realized he couldn't.

His new light body needed different food seeds and insects, like the birds ate. He couldn't digest clover anymore.

He flew away, feeling strangely homesick for a life he still technically had.

[Illustration: Taro flying above a group of happy tortoises eating clover in a meadow, looking down at them longingly, unable to join, feeling isolated from his own family]

Page 9

On the evening of day two, a terrible storm rolled in. Thunder crashed and lightning split the sky.

Every bird found shelter in holes and nests. But Taro didn't have a nest. He didn't fit in bird holes.

He huddled under a leaf, shaking. If he'd had his shell, he would have simply pulled in and been safe.

Ruby found him and tried to cover him with her wings, but she was too small.

'I miss my shell,' Taro whispered. The words surprised him. But they were true.

[Illustration: Taro huddling miserably under a large leaf during a thunderstorm, tiny Ruby trying to shelter him with her small wings, lightning flashing in the dark sky, Taro looking homesick]

Page 10

On day three the last day something happened that changed everything.

Taro was flying over the river when he heard screaming. A family of baby mice had fallen into the rushing water!

The birds flew overhead, wanting to help, but they couldn't dive into water their wings would get waterlogged.

Taro dove down to help. But without his shell, the current pushed him around like a leaf. He was too light!

A real tortoise heavy, steady, strong could have waded in and carried the mice on their shell. But Taro couldn't.

[Illustration: Baby mice struggling in a rushing stream, birds hovering helplessly above, Taro trying to dive in but being pushed away by the current, too light without his shell to be steady in water]

Page 11

Just then, old Uncle Bato, a tortoise from Taro's family, came walking by with his heavy, magnificent shell.

Without hesitating, Uncle Bato waded into the stream. The current pushed against him but his heavy shell and strong legs held firm.

One by one, he placed the baby mice on his broad shell and carried them safely to shore.

The mother mouse wept with gratitude. The birds cheered from above.

And Taro watched from the air, feeling something he'd never felt before: he wished he was a tortoise again.

[Illustration: Uncle Bato the tortoise wading steadily into the stream, baby mice climbing onto his broad shell, the current unable to push him, while Taro watches from above feeling helpless and envious of the tortoise]

Page 12

Taro landed next to Uncle Bato. 'You saved them! Because of your shell! Because you're heavy and strong!'

Uncle Bato smiled slowly, as tortoises do. 'Yes. My shell is my gift. It protects me, carries others, and keeps me steady.'

'I gave mine up,' Taro said sadly. 'I thought wings were better. I thought flying was everything.'

'Flying is wonderful,' Uncle Bato said. 'But so is being steady. So is being strong. So is being able to weather any storm.'

'The things you thought were weaknesses, Taro your shell, your slowness, your weight they were strengths all along.'

[Illustration: Taro and Uncle Bato on the riverbank, the rescued mice safe and waving thank you, Uncle Bato wise and kind, Taro looking at him with new understanding and appreciation]

Page 13

When the sun set on day three, the owl Wisdom appeared again.

'Your three days are up,' she said. 'Would you like to keep your wings? Or would you like your shell back?'

Every day of his life before this, Taro would have chosen wings without hesitating.

But now he knew what he'd lost. Protection. Strength. Steadiness. The ability to help in ways birds never could.

'Please,' Taro said. 'Give me back my shell. I know now what I am and what I am is wonderful.'

[Illustration: Wisdom the owl appearing at sunset, Taro looking up at her with peaceful certainty, choosing his shell over wings, the evening sky golden behind them]

Page 14

In another swirl of golden feathers, the wings dissolved and Taro's beautiful shell returned.

It settled onto his back heavy, solid, perfect. Like putting on a warm coat after being cold.

Taro pulled his head and legs inside, just to feel the safety of it. The comfort. The protection.

'I missed you,' he whispered to his shell. And he meant it with his whole heart.

He had never appreciated his shell until it was gone. Now he would never take it for granted again.

[Illustration: Taro's shell reforming on his back in a magical golden swirl, Taro pulling into his shell with a blissful smile, feeling safe and whole again, relief and happiness radiating from him]

Page 15

Ruby landed on his shell and tapped it with her beak. 'Welcome back, old friend!'

'Thank you for flying with me, Ruby,' Taro said. 'Flying was amazing. But I belong on the ground.'

'Of course you do!' Ruby chirped. 'I fly, and you walk. I'm fast, and you're steady.

That's what makes us such good friends!'

Taro smiled. 'I think I finally understand. We're not supposed to be the same. We're supposed to be ourselves.'

[Illustration: Ruby perched happily on Taro's restored shell, both friends smiling at each other, a perfect partnership of different abilities, sunny valley around them]

Page 16

From that day on, Taro never wished for wings again.

Instead, he discovered all the amazing things about being a tortoise that he'd never noticed before.

His shell was a shelter when it rained. A table when friends visited. A slide for baby mice to play on.

His slowness meant he noticed tiny beautiful things the fast animals missed dew drops, new mushrooms, shy caterpillars.

His weight meant he was steady in storms, strong in currents, and an anchor for those who needed one.

[Illustration: Taro happily being a tortoise baby mice sliding down his shell, him studying a tiny mushroom up close, standing steady in wind enjoying all the things that make him unique]

Page 17

And whenever Taro met a young animal who wished to be something different a fish who wanted to climb trees, a rabbit who wanted to swim he would share his story.

'I once wanted wings,' he'd say. 'I even had them for three days.'

'What happened?' they'd ask, wide-eyed.

'I learned that what I thought were weaknesses were actually my greatest strengths. The things that make you different are the things that make you wonderful.'

'Be yourself. Fully, proudly, wonderfully yourself. That's better than any wings in the world.'

[Illustration: Taro surrounded by young animals of various species listening to his wisdom, all looking inspired, in a beautiful meadow setting, Taro content and wise]

Page 18

That afternoon, Taro did something he'd never done before he went swimming. Without wings weighing him down, his shell made him perfectly buoyant in the water. He floated on the pond's surface like a boat, gentle and steady, while fish swam beneath him and dragonflies rested on his shell. 'I can do things birds can't!' he laughed. 'I can swim! I can carry things on my back! I'm waterproof!' He splashed and paddled, discovering a whole new joy he'd been too busy envying birds to notice.

[Illustration: Taro happily swimming in a pond, floating perfectly on the water with his shell, fish swimming below, dragonflies resting on his shell, pure joy at discovering his water abilities]

Page 19

The next day, a rainstorm came, and all the other animals scrambled for shelter.

Taro simply pulled into his shell and listened to the beautiful sound of rain drumming on his back.

It was like having his own personal house wherever he went! Warm, dry, and safe.

When the storm passed, Taro popped his head out refreshed while everyone else was soaked and shivering.

'Best roof in the world,' he grinned, patting his shell proudly.

[Illustration: Taro contentedly inside his shell during a rainstorm, rain drumming on his shell, other animals soaked nearby, Taro popping out after dry and happy]

Page 20

Taro also discovered the gift of slowness. Because he moved slowly, he noticed everything. He found rare herbs that the fast animals ran past. He spotted a beautiful crystal hidden in the moss.

He watched a caterpillar build its cocoon from start to finish something no bird would ever be patient enough to see.

'Speed makes you miss things,' Taro realized. 'Slowness makes you find them.'

[Illustration: Taro discovering a beautiful crystal in the moss, watching a caterpillar spin its cocoon, noticing tiny wonders all around him that faster animals miss entirely]

Page 21

From that day on, Taro never wished for wings again.

Instead, he discovered all the amazing things about being a tortoise that he'd never noticed before.

His shell was a shelter when it rained. A table when friends visited. A slide for baby mice to play on.

His slowness meant he noticed tiny beautiful things the fast animals missed dew drops, new mushrooms, shy caterpillars.

His weight meant he was steady in storms, strong in currents, and an anchor for those who needed one.

[Illustration: Taro happily being a tortoise baby mice sliding down his shell, him studying a tiny mushroom up close, standing steady in wind enjoying all the things that make him unique]

Page 22

And whenever Taro met a young animal who wished to be something different a fish who wanted to climb trees, a rabbit who wanted to swim he would share his story.

'I once wanted wings,' he'd say. 'I even had them for three days.'

'What happened?' they'd ask, wide-eyed.

'I learned that what I thought were weaknesses were actually my greatest strengths. The things that make you different are the things that make you wonderful.'

'Be yourself. Fully, proudly, wonderfully yourself. That's better than any wings in the world.'

[Illustration: Taro surrounded by young animals of various species listening to his wisdom, all looking inspired, in a beautiful meadow setting, Taro content and wise]

Page 23

So remember: you are not supposed to be like everyone else.

Maybe you're quiet in a world of loud people. Maybe you're slow in a world of fast ones.

Maybe you're different in ways that feel awkward or strange.

But those differences? They're your superpowers. Your shell. Your unique gift to the world.

Don't wish them away. Discover why they're wonderful. Because they ARE wonderful.

And so are you. Exactly as you are. Wings or no wings.

[Illustration: A beautiful final image of the Emerald Valley with all the different animals tortoises, birds, fish, rabbits each doing what they do best, a celebration of diversity and being yourself]

Page 24

Here is something to try, dear reader:

Instead of thinking about what you wish you could do, make a list of what you CAN do.

Write down five things that make you YOU. Five things you are good at. Five things that make you different from everyone else.

Maybe you are patient. Maybe you are creative. Maybe you are strong, or kind, or funny, or observant.

Those are not just traits. Those are your superpowers. Your shell. Wear them proudly.

[Illustration: A child writing a list of their own unique qualities and strengths, each one drawn as a shield or superpower emblem, celebrating their unique traits]

Page 25

And whenever you catch yourself wishing you were someone else stop.

Instead, ask: 'What can I do today that only I can do? What makes me special that I have not even discovered yet?'

The answers might surprise you. Because you, dear reader, are wonderfully and uniquely made.

There is no one else in the whole world exactly like you. And the world needs exactly what only YOU can give.

So be yourself. Fully. Proudly. Beautifully. Just like Taro learned to be.

[Illustration: A child looking at their own reflection in a pond with a smile, seeing their unique self clearly for the first time, accepting and loving who they are, sunshine and flowers around them]

The Moral of the Story

Appreciate What Makes You Unique

Taro learned that wishing to be someone else means losing what makes YOU special. His shell, his slowness, his weight all the things he thought were weaknesses turned out to be incredible strengths. The same is true for you! The things that make you different are not flaws. They are features. They are gifts. They are exactly what the world needs. Instead of wishing you were like someone else, discover the superpower hiding in what makes you, you.

Discussion Questions for Parents

After reading this story together, talk about these questions:

1. What's something about yourself that you sometimes wish was different? Can you think of how it might actually be a strength?
2. Why do you think Taro missed his shell after only two days without it?
3. What are some things that tortoises can do that birds can't? What can birds do that tortoises can't?
4. Is it bad to admire what other people can do? What's the difference between admiring others and wishing you were them?
5. What makes YOU unique? What can you do that nobody else does quite the same way?

About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a storyteller who believes every child deserves stories that spark imagination, build character, and fill hearts with wonder.

His stories are crafted to help children understand important life lessons through adventure, friendship, and the magic of imagination.

When not writing, Daniel enjoys spending time with family, exploring nature, and dreaming up new worlds for young readers to discover.

Thank you for reading! If your child enjoyed this story, please look for other books in the collection.